

Inclusion of Vulnerable Children in Emergency Education in Sub-Saharan Africa:

A Scoping Review of Approaches, Barriers, and Facilitators

Authors: Magnus Suuh (1), Doris Ndang (2), Delphine Njoya (3), Mubarak Isa F (4), Linda Ankiambom (5), Rachine Duna (6), Mark Tata Kelese (7), Claude Dzelamonyuy Fotso (7), Rigobert Pambe (7), Patrick Mbah Okwen (7)

1. United Councils and Cities of Cameroon, Bamenda, Northwest Region
2. EDUCARE Nursery and Primary School, Bamenda, Cameroon
3. CBC Education Department, Bamenda, Cameroon
4. The University of Bamenda, Bambili, Cameroon
5. Green Partners Association, Bamenda, Cameroon
6. BUST, Bamenda, Cameroon
7. Effective Basic Services

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Ethical approval: Ethical approval is not required. This is a scoping review involving secondary analysis of published and publicly available literature only. No primary data will be collected from human participants.

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that identified this research question as a priority, but have not been involved in the design, delivery, or evaluation of any specific inclusive education intervention under review.

Reviewer roles: Content expertise is provided by Magnus Suuh, Doris Ntang, Delphine Njoya, and Linda Ankiambom. Methodological leadership, including guidance on JBI scoping review methodology and PRISMA-ScR reporting, is provided by Mubarak Isa F. Information retrieval and database searches will be coordinated by Rachine Duna with support from Mubarak Isa F. Thematic synthesis and descriptive summary will be a shared team task under the methodological lead of Mubarak Isa F. Patrick Okwen (eBASE Africa) will serve as independent adjudicator for unresolved screening or extraction disagreements.

Authors' contribution: All authors contributed to the conception and design of this scoping review protocol. MS, DN, DNj, MIF and LA provided content expertise on inclusive and emergency education and contributed to the framing of the review questions and eligibility criteria. RP and MTK provided methodological leadership, including guidance on JBI scoping review methodology and PRISMA-ScR reporting, and will oversee screening, data extraction and synthesis procedures. CDF, RD developed and will coordinate the search strategy and database searches, with methodological support from MTK. MTK and CDF coordinated the Northwest Region Community of Practice and Evidence Rush processes through which the review question was prioritised, and contributed to drafting the introduction and rationale. PMO provided senior oversight, will serve as independent adjudicator for unresolved screening or extraction disagreements, and critically reviewed the protocol. All authors reviewed and approved the final version of this protocol and agree to be accountable for its content.

Abstract

Background

In Sub-Saharan Africa, emergencies such as armed conflicts, climate-induced disasters, and disease outbreaks disproportionately affect vulnerable children, including children with disabilities, orphans, internally displaced children, and those from extreme poverty or marginalised groups. While emergency education settings such as temporary learning spaces, refugee camp schools, and accelerated learning programmes are critical for protection and development, these children frequently face exclusion from access, participation, and learning. Evidence on how to promote inclusion in these contexts remains fragmented and has not, to date, been systematically mapped. A national Evidence Gap Map for Cameroon identified only 8 of 55 studies as addressing equity and inclusion as an outcome, and not a single systematic review or meta-analysis was found in the entire evidence base (Pambe et al., 2025).

Objective

This scoping review aims to map available evidence on the approaches, barriers, facilitators, and outcomes associated with the inclusion of vulnerable children in emergency education settings in Sub-Saharan Africa.

Inclusion criteria

Studies will be included if they address vulnerable children aged 3 to 18 years in emergency education settings in Sub-Saharan Africa (Population), focus on inclusive approaches, barriers, facilitators, and strategies related to participation and learning (Concept), and are set in formal or non-formal emergency education contexts (Context). Peer-reviewed primary research, programme evaluations, grey literature, and policy documents will be considered. Studies from non-emergency or stable development contexts and opinion pieces without empirical grounding will be excluded.

Methods

This review follows the Joanna Briggs Institute (JBI) methodology for scoping reviews. It will be reported using the Preferred Reporting Items for Systematic Reviews and Meta-Analyses Extension for Scoping Reviews (PRISMA-ScR). A three-step search strategy will be applied across seven academic databases and complemented by grey literature sources. Two independent

reviewers will screen all records at the title and abstract stage and at the full-text stage. Data will be extracted using a standardised form and synthesised through descriptive numerical summary and thematic analysis in MAXQDA. No formal critical appraisal will be conducted, consistent with JBI guidance. The review is expected to be completed by November 2026.

Introduction

Education is widely recognised as a fundamental human right and an essential component of humanitarian response during emergencies (Burde et al., 2017; The Alliance, 2022). Beyond its academic function, education provides protection, psychosocial support, social stability, and opportunities for personal development for children affected by crises (Burde et al., 2017; Loughry et al., 2022). In emergency settings, access to quality education can help restore a sense of normalcy, reduce vulnerability to exploitation and abuse, and support long-term recovery and resilience (EdTech Hub, 2020; INEE, 2023; The Alliance, 2022).

Despite global commitments to equitable access to education through the Sustainable Development Goals (SDG 4) and the Education 2030 Agenda, emergencies continue to disrupt educational systems and disproportionately affect the most vulnerable children (Palik et al., 2023; UNESCO, 2023). Armed conflicts, natural disasters, forced displacement, and public health emergencies have led to unprecedented levels of educational disruption worldwide (Palik et al., 2023; UNESCO, 2023). Children who are already marginalised due to disability, gender, socioeconomic status, displacement, or minority status often experience compounded barriers that limit their access to educational opportunities during crises (Palik et al., 2023; UNICEF, 2023).

The concept of inclusion in emergency education has gained increasing attention among governments, humanitarian agencies, and development partners (The Alliance, 2022; Skovdal and Campbell, 2015). Inclusive emergency education seeks to ensure that all children, regardless of their background or vulnerabilities, can access, participate in, and benefit from educational services during emergencies. Inclusion extends beyond physical access to schools and encompasses meaningful participation, equitable learning opportunities, supportive learning environments, and the removal of social, cultural, institutional, and environmental barriers (Ainscow and Miles, 2008; INEE, 2023).

Various approaches have been implemented to promote inclusion in emergency education settings, including disability-inclusive practices, gender-responsive programming, teacher training initiatives, flexible learning modalities, community engagement strategies, psychosocial support services, language support programmes, and the integration of digital and remote learning technologies (EdTech Hub, 2020; Rose et al., 2020; The Alliance, 2022). While these interventions

have shown promise in different contexts, their implementation and effectiveness vary considerably across settings and populations (EdTech Hub, 2020; Palik et al., 2023; Skovdal and Campbell, 2015).

Existing literature on the inclusion of vulnerable children in emergency education is diverse and spans multiple disciplines, including education, humanitarian studies, public health, disability studies, and social policy (Palik et al., 2023; The Alliance, 2022). Evidence is scattered across peer-reviewed publications, policy reports, and humanitarian programme documents, making it difficult to obtain a comprehensive understanding of current knowledge, emerging trends, and research gaps. The broad range of vulnerable populations and emergency contexts represented in the literature means that an evidence-mapping approach is more appropriate than a narrowly focused effectiveness review (Arksey and O'Malley, 2005; Palik et al., 2023).

The relevance of this gap is particularly acute in Sub-Saharan Africa. A national Evidence Gap Map produced under the Unlocking Data Initiative for Cameroon identified only 8 of 55 studies as addressing equity and inclusion as an outcome, and the Northwest Region Community of Practice Evidence Rush rated the question of how educational institutions can accommodate learners with disabilities and other vulnerable groups as Red, indicating no reliable synthesised evidence was found (Pambe et al., 2025; Pambe, Fotso, Kelese et al., 2026). Nationally, approximately 72% of children in Cameroon cannot read fluently by age 10 (UNESCO, 2022), and over 1.5 million school-age children across crisis-affected regions require urgent educational assistance (UNICEF, 2025). These figures illustrate the scale and urgency of the challenge.

A preliminary search of MEDLINE, the Cochrane Database of Systematic Reviews, JBI Evidence Synthesis, and the Campbell Collaboration Library did not identify any current or underway systematic or scoping review specifically addressing inclusive education approaches for vulnerable children across different emergency contexts in Sub-Saharan Africa. Reviews that do exist tend to focus on single vulnerable groups or single intervention types rather than mapping the full landscape of populations, strategies, barriers, and facilitators together. This scoping review is therefore needed to establish, for the first time, a structured account of what is and is not known on this question across the region.

Objective

This scoping review aims to map the existing evidence on the inclusion of vulnerable children in emergency education settings in Sub-Saharan Africa. Specifically, the review will identify the populations represented in the literature, examine the strategies and interventions used to promote inclusion, explore barriers and facilitators influencing participation, document the nature and role of intersecting vulnerabilities across gender, disability, displacement, and poverty, and summarise reported educational, social, and psychosocial outcomes.

Review Questions

Overarching question: What evidence exists on the approaches used to promote the inclusion of vulnerable children in emergency education settings in Sub-Saharan Africa, including the barriers, facilitators, strategies, and outcomes associated with their participation, access, and learning?

Sub-questions:

1. What groups of vulnerable children are represented in studies of emergency education in Sub-Saharan Africa?
2. What approaches, interventions, and practices have been implemented to promote the inclusion of vulnerable children in emergency education settings in Sub-Saharan Africa, and what evidence exists on their reach and effectiveness?
3. What barriers influence the inclusion of vulnerable children in emergency education in Sub-Saharan Africa, and how do these differ across vulnerable groups and emergency contexts?
4. What facilitators enable the inclusion of vulnerable children in emergency education in Sub-Saharan Africa, and how do these differ across vulnerable groups and emergency contexts?
5. How do intersecting vulnerabilities, such as gender, disability, displacement, and poverty, shape children's inclusion in emergency education in Sub-Saharan Africa?

Methods

Search Strategy and Information Sources

The search strategy will be developed in accordance with the Joanna Briggs Institute (JBI) methodology for scoping reviews and will aim to identify both published and unpublished evidence on the inclusion of vulnerable children in emergency education settings. A comprehensive three-step search strategy will be employed.

In the first step, a preliminary search will be conducted in PubMed and ERIC to identify relevant articles and examine the keywords, phrases, and indexing terms used in the literature. The identified terms will inform the development of a comprehensive search strategy for all subsequent database searches.

In the second step, the search strategy will be adapted and applied across seven electronic databases: PubMed, ERIC (via the ProQuest interface where institutional access is available, or the free eric.ed.gov / api.ies.ed.gov interface where it is not), Web of Science Core Collection, PsycINFO, Scopus, African Journals Online (AJOL), and the British Education Index. Web of Science Core Collection, PsycINFO, Scopus, and the British Education Index require institutional subscription access; where this is not available to the review team, the gap will be documented transparently in the review's search log. AJOL's own search interface disallows automated, scripted querying under its robots.txt, but is directly reachable through a standard browser session; where reachable this way it will be queried directly, with the top relevance-ranked page(s) fully screened given its very large, effectively unbounded result counts for broad multi-term queries. Where only scripted access is available to support the search, a site-restricted web search (via DuckDuckGo, since Google returns a CAPTCHA challenge on repeated site-restricted queries and Bing silently drops both site: filters and quoted phrase terms) will substitute for AJOL's own search tool. These databases were selected to provide broad coverage of education, social sciences, psychology, humanitarian studies, disability studies, and African research. Scopus was specifically included to extend interdisciplinary coverage and reduce the risk of missing relevant literature at the intersections of these fields.

In the third step, the reference lists of all included studies and relevant review articles will be manually searched to identify additional eligible studies. Forward citation searching will also be conducted where appropriate.

To ensure comprehensive coverage, grey literature sources will also be searched. These include the Inter-Agency Network for Education in Emergencies (INEE), the United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees (UNHCR), UNICEF, Save the Children, and the World Bank Open Knowledge Repository. African institutional repositories will also be searched, prioritising those identified via the OpenDOAR directory (www.opendoar.org) as holding open-access education or social-science collections; since OpenDOAR is a directory rather than a searchable aggregator of full-text content, each identified repository's own search interface will be queried individually rather than treating OpenDOAR itself as a single searchable source (for example, the Makerere University Institutional Repository, Uganda, and the University of Cape Town's OpenUCT, South Africa, with further candidate repositories for later passes including the University of Nairobi, the University of Ghana's UGSpace, and Addis Ababa University). Relevant reports, policy documents, programme evaluations, and technical publications will be considered for inclusion.

The search strategy is structured around the three elements of the Population, Concept, Context (PCC) framework, translated into three Boolean search blocks combined using AND operators. The first block covers terms describing vulnerable children. The second block covers terms describing inclusive approaches, barriers, facilitators, and strategies. The third block covers terms describing emergency education settings in Sub-Saharan Africa.

A sample search strategy for PubMed is presented below. Country-specific terms are not included in the geographic block in order to avoid introducing geographic bias by naming only some Sub-Saharan African countries. The regional filter is considered sufficient for the scoping purposes of this review, and country-specific supplementary searches may be conducted if initial yield is insufficient. Reviewers should note two platform-specific query-design considerations. First, PubMed's automatic term mapping can stem single generic terms, such as emergency, conflict, or displaced, into broad, unrelated clinical or psychological subject headings when they are not paired with an explicit school or education term; such terms should be anchored with an education-specific term or tightly quoted phrase to avoid this over-broadening. Second, ERIC's own search interface, whether accessed via ProQuest or its free public API, performs loose, word-level matching within indexed description fields rather than strict phrase-level Boolean logic, so a single literal Boolean string combining several multi-word phrase blocks may return results that share

little topical relevance with the query as written; the search should be supplemented with a series of narrower, single-concept-pair queries where this occurs.

(“vulnerable children” OR “children with disabilities” OR “disabled children” OR “refugee children” OR “displaced children” OR “internally displaced children” OR “children in emergencies” OR “out of school children” OR “marginalised children” OR “marginalized children”) AND (“inclusive education” OR “disability inclusive education” OR “educational inclusion” OR “special educational needs” OR “reasonable accommodation” OR “equity in education” OR “barriers to learning” OR “barriers to schooling” OR “gender responsive education” OR “inclusive schooling”) AND (“primary education” OR “primary school” OR “early grade” OR “foundational learning” OR “foundational education” OR “basic education” OR “early childhood education” OR “foundational literacy” OR “foundational numeracy” OR “elementary education”) AND (“education in emergencies” OR “emergency education” OR “humanitarian education” OR “conflict-affected education” OR “refugee education” OR “fragile contexts” OR “crisis-affected education” OR “temporary learning” OR “accelerated education”) AND (“Sub-Saharan Africa” OR “West Africa” OR “East Africa” OR “Southern Africa” OR “Central Africa” OR “Cameroon” OR “Kenya” OR “Uganda” OR “Tanzania” OR “Ethiopia” OR “Nigeria” OR “Malawi” OR “Rwanda” OR “South Sudan” OR “Mali” OR “Niger” OR “Chad” OR “Congo” OR “Zambia” OR “Mozambique” OR “Zimbabwe”)

The search will be restricted to studies published in English and French, reflecting the language capabilities of the review team. The team acknowledges that this restriction may introduce language bias by excluding relevant work published in Portuguese, Arabic, or other languages spoken in Sub-Saharan Africa, and this will be noted as a limitation in the final review. No publication date restrictions will be applied. All retrieved records will be imported into Rayyan, a systematic review management platform, for screening and duplicate removal. The final search strategies for all databases will be reported in the completed review to ensure transparency and reproducibility.

Study selection approach

The study selection process will follow JBI methodology for scoping reviews and will be reported using the PRISMA-ScR flow diagram. A two-stage screening process will be employed.

At the first stage, two reviewers will independently screen all records at title and abstract level against the predetermined inclusion and exclusion criteria. Records that clearly do not meet the eligibility criteria will be excluded, while records that appear relevant or where eligibility is uncertain will be retained for full-text review. Before commencing screening, a pilot exercise will be undertaken on a sample of 25 records to ensure consistency in the application of the criteria. Discrepancies will be resolved through discussion. Where agreement cannot be reached, an independent reviewer will serve as an adjudicator.

At the second stage, full texts of all records considered potentially eligible will be retrieved and assessed independently by the same two reviewers. Each reviewer will assess each record against the predefined PCC inclusion criteria. Reasons for exclusion at this stage will be documented and reported. Disagreements will be resolved through discussion and, where necessary, referred to the adjudicator.

The number of records identified, screened, assessed for eligibility, and included will be presented in a PRISMA-ScR flow diagram.

Eligibility criteria

Eligibility is defined using the Population, Concept, Context (PCC) framework for scoping reviews, as follows.

Population: Vulnerable children aged 3 to 18 years in emergency education settings in Sub-Saharan Africa, as defined by the World Bank regional classification. Vulnerable groups include children with disabilities, orphaned children, child heads of household, children from ethnic or linguistic minorities, children affected by displacement, and children from extreme poverty. Studies focused exclusively on adult stakeholders without reference to child outcomes will be excluded.

Concept: Approaches to promote inclusion, including barriers (social, cultural, economic, institutional, environmental, and policy-related factors), facilitators (supportive policies,

community engagement, teacher training, accessibility measures, and resource provision), and specific strategies such as teacher training, accessible infrastructure, psychosocial support, and cash transfers for school fees. Outcomes of interest include access, participation, learning outcomes, and psychosocial wellbeing. Studies that address only data collection without reference to inclusive approaches or child outcomes will be excluded.

Context: Formal or non-formal education settings operating during humanitarian emergencies, including refugee and displacement camps, host community schools, temporary learning centres, and accelerated education programmes, within Sub-Saharan Africa. Studies conducted exclusively outside Sub-Saharan Africa will be excluded, as will studies in stable, non-emergency development contexts.

Types of sources: Peer-reviewed primary research (qualitative, quantitative, and mixed-methods), programme evaluations, grey literature reports, and policy briefs will be considered. Systematic reviews will be used for reference scanning but will not serve as primary data sources. Fact sheets, newspaper articles, and editorials without empirical grounding will be excluded.

Language and date: Studies published in English and French will be included. Studies in other languages without an available English or French abstract will be excluded. No publication date restrictions will be applied.

Data extraction

Data extraction will follow JBI methodology for scoping reviews. A standardised data extraction form has been developed (see Appendix A) and will be pilot tested on three included studies before full extraction. Any necessary modifications will be agreed by the full review team before proceeding.

Data extraction will be conducted independently by two reviewers. Extracted data will be compared and disagreements resolved through discussion. Where necessary, the adjudicator will be consulted. The following information will be extracted from each included source: source characteristics (author or authors, year of publication, country or region, publication type); study characteristics (design, methodological approach, data collection methods, sample size, reported limitations); emergency context (type of emergency and educational setting); population

characteristics (category of vulnerable children, age range); gender, equity, and social inclusion dimensions (whether and how findings are disaggregated by gender, disability, displacement, or other equity dimension, and whether intersecting vulnerabilities are examined); barriers to inclusion; facilitators of inclusion; strategies and interventions described; reported outcomes (access, enrolment, attendance, participation, retention, learning achievement, psychosocial wellbeing, social inclusion); and key findings and recommendations.

As this review aims to map the breadth and nature of existing evidence rather than evaluate intervention effectiveness, formal critical appraisal of methodological quality will not be undertaken, consistent with JBI guidance for scoping reviews.

Analysis and presentation of results

The synthesis of evidence will follow JBI methodology and will focus on mapping the extent, nature, and characteristics of the available evidence. Given the anticipated heterogeneity of the included sources in terms of study design, populations, emergency contexts, and outcomes, a narrative and descriptive approach will be adopted. Coding will be conducted using MAXQDA, a qualitative data analysis software package, to ensure consistency and traceability across the coding process.

A descriptive numerical summary will be undertaken to provide an overview of the characteristics of the included sources. Extracted data will be summarised using frequencies and counts to describe the distribution of studies by publication year, country or region, emergency context, vulnerable population group, study design, and publication type. This summary will help identify patterns in the literature and highlight areas where evidence is concentrated or absent. Findings will be presented through tables, charts, and graphs where appropriate.

A thematic analysis will then be conducted to synthesise findings relating to the review objectives and research questions. Data will be coded using a combination of deductive and inductive approaches. Deductive coding will be informed by the review questions and the PCC framework, while inductive coding will allow additional themes and concepts to emerge from the data. The analysis will identify and synthesise recurring themes across five areas: vulnerable populations represented in the literature; strategies and interventions implemented; barriers to inclusion across

groups and contexts; facilitators of inclusion across groups and contexts; and intersecting vulnerabilities, including gender, disability, displacement, and poverty.

Results will be presented through narrative descriptions, tables, figures, and diagrams. The study selection process will be illustrated using a PRISMA-ScR flow diagram. An evidence summary table will capture key characteristics of each included source. A conceptual map will also be developed to visually illustrate the relationships among barriers, facilitators, strategies, and outcomes identified across the literature, supporting the interpretation of findings and the identification of knowledge gaps and research priorities.

Projected Timeline

The review is structured around the Northwest Region CoP DBIR Cycle 3 implementation plan, running from May to November 2026, as follows.

- May to June 2026: Protocol finalisation and OSF registration, prior to commencing any searches.
- June to July 2026: Database searches across all seven academic databases and grey literature sources.
- July 2026: Title and abstract screening, with pilot exercise completed before full screening begins.
- August 2026: Full-text screening, with reasons for exclusion documented throughout.
- August to September 2026: Data extraction using the standardised form, with pilot testing on three studies before full extraction.
- September to October 2026: Thematic synthesis and descriptive numerical summary in MAXQDA.
- October 2026: Draft report preparation and peer feedback at Workshop 3.
- October to November 2026: Final manuscript revision, submission, and presentation at the CoP plenary.

Notable deviations from the methodological approach

This protocol outlines the planned methodology to ensure transparency, rigour, and reproducibility throughout the review. The methods described will be adhered to in line with JBI guidance. However, scoping reviews often involve iterative processes, particularly during study selection and evidence mapping, where adjustments may become necessary in response to the volume, breadth, and nature of the retrieved literature.

If any modifications become necessary, these will be carefully documented, clearly justified, and transparently reported in the final review manuscript under a dedicated Deviations from Protocol subsection. Potential deviations may include the inclusion of additional grey literature sources identified as highly relevant during the review, or refinement of the thematic coding framework in response to unexpected patterns in the evidence. Minor adjustments to eligibility criteria may also be required to improve clarity or feasibility, for example to refine inclusion parameters for studies that do not allow meaningful extraction of child-specific data.

The imposition of a publication date restriction is not a pre-specified deviation in this protocol. Any such decision would require explicit justification and full documentation of its implications for the review findings before it could be implemented.

Any changes will be made only after careful consideration by the full review team and the adjudicator, and will not compromise the integrity of the review objectives. At the protocol stage, no deviations are anticipated.

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Appendix A: Draft Data Extraction Form